



Number of times India has played Asian Associates

UAE: 2

China: 0

Japan: 1

Thailand: 4

Malaysia: 3

Hong Kong China: 1

Indonesia: 0

(Asia Cup and Asian Games participants)

ahead at the Olympics, that would be an oversimplification. At the end of the day, Olympic cricket — as it stands — is still a T20 knockout tournament, the sport's most fickle format. It cares not for past laurels. Fortune only favours the brave here, as India learned at the Birmingham CWG when it watched Australia don gold while it made do, grudgingly, with silver.

For all the expansion, the view from the top remains fairly myopic. Players being dragged into the political theatre of handshakes and trophy tug-of-war took the sheen off what is, in theory, one of the most promising learning opportunities for teams on the fringes of the power core. If one wants to be doggedly apolitical, two high-importance tournaments in 2026 without television referrals and held at a single venue are no vote of confidence in the efforts of the custodians of the sport. The ICC can't wash its hands off either, as the inaugural Women's Champions Trophy — taken away from Sri Lanka due to political interference in administration — is due to be held across just two Tier 2 Indian venues.

While the prosperous continue to

prosper, Pakistan, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh face tumultuous transitions within and outside the team. Outside India, franchise cricket is not a reality or a liberating financial avenue for any other Asian nation. FairBreak Global, an ICC-based independent initiative that brought several Asian Associate nations much-needed game time with stars from SENA countries, is now defunct.

Indonesia, for all its ambition, still played the Asia Cup without a shirt sponsor, while a Full Member nation like Afghanistan is still being shielded from accountability for failing the cardinal principle of said membership — mandatorily fielding a women's team.

Hierarchy masquerades as competition in Asian cricket, with one crown after another for those already on top, while the rest are left arguing over scraps of legitimacy. Showpieces without follow-ups, expansion without equity and Olympic ambition without Olympic-standard competitiveness will only widen the gap the game is desperate to bridge.

All guns blazing: Shafali Verma (top) and Smriti Mandhana (below) were the top scorers in the tournament and final, respectively.

